

Chapter 4

Uninflectedness as a factor in agreement loss

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In some weakly inflecting-fusional Romance languages, there has been a significant shift towards an isolating word structure, where uninflectedness has become more common, especially in certain areas of grammar. French nominal morphology is a well-known example, but many Italo-Romance varieties, both north and south of Tuscany, have similarly reduced inflection distinctions. This has led to a less systematic expression of agreement compared to Latin or standard Italian. In this paper, I expand on previous research to examine how uninflectedness emerges in these Romance varieties and how it interacts with agreement. The primary focus is on verb agreement with direct objects, particularly through participles. Most Romance languages exhibit four-cell paradigms in this area, which can show syncretisms or uninflectability due to regular sound change. The notion of uninflectability can also be extended to cases where one feature, usually expressed cumulatively in inflected words, fails to be expressed, or where there is asymmetrical marking of features, as seen in some Italo-Romance dialects with uninflecting roots and inflecting endings in the same participle. This paper explores the implications of these phenomena for agreement.

1 Introduction

Among the (weakly) inflecting-fusional Romance languages, some have gone a long way towards generalizing an isolating word structure, making uninflectedness the rule rather than the exception, at least in some areas of grammar. The best-known case is French nominal morphology, but a large subset of the Italo-Romance varieties – both north and south of Tuscany, whose dialects provided the basis for the standard language – parallels French in having reduced



distinctions in inflection in general, in such a way that agreement has come to be signalled much less systematically than it used to be in Latin and still is in standard Italian.

In the present paper, elaborating on previous work (see e.g. Loporcaro 2010, 2015, Loporcaro & Paciaroni 2021), I show the ways in which uninflectedness enters these Romance varieties and the various ways in which it interacts with agreement. Among the evidence considered, special attention will be paid to verb agreement with the direct object, whose target is a participle within a periphrastic verb form. In such participles, most Romance languages display four-cell paradigms which may show syncretisms (along patterns classified in Loporcaro 2011) or uninflectability, usually as a product of regular sound change (the case exemplified above with French). Spencer (2020: 143) stretches the notion uninflectability a little bit, to also cover cases in which just one feature among those otherwise expressed cumulatively in the inflection of words from a given part of speech (its *inflectional signature*) fails to be expressed. Another way in which the notion can be extended is to cover asymmetrical marking of distinct features in multiple exponence: in Italo-Romance dialects, thus, one most often encounters uninflecting roots combined with inflecting endings in the same participle, but one can also observe inflecting roots co-occurring with either uninflecting or inflecting endings and, in case both the root and the suffix inflect, they need not encode exactly the same feature-value combinations. I will explore the consequences of these different distributions for agreement.

To pave the way for this, after a quick prologue (Section 2), I will first sketch (in Section 3) an inventory of the different kinds of uninflectability, elaborating on Spencer (2020) and focusing in particular on the types of partial uninflectability. Among these types, I will finally concentrate on one, which I will call *sublexemic partial uninflectability*, showing (in Section 4) how this is involved in the cases of agreement loss mentioned above. As a by-product, the present discussion also reads as a plea for the investigation of dialect variation in Romance, which provides language typologists with exciting and at times unparalleled data.

2 Prologue: inflecting the uninflecting in Italo-Romance

Given what has been said in Section 1, it is clear that, adopting Spencer's (2020: 143) distinction between *uninflecting* and *uninflectable* lexemes, the present paper is about the latter, which belong to parts of speech which do otherwise inflect in the relevant language. However, for a contribution focusing on Romance in a volume on uninflectedness, it is appropriate to at least quickly mention the Indo-European variety which probably goes the farthest in inflecting the uninflecting

(or what is usually uninflecting cross-linguistically), that is Ripano. In this Italo-Romance dialect, spoken in Ripatransone (in the Marche, central-eastern Italy), through the vagaries of sound change even adverbs (of manner, as in (1), but others too) or *wh*-words (as in (2)) have come to agree with the clause subject inflecting for gender and number (examples from Paciaroni & Loporcaro 2018):

- (1) a. 'va a l-a 'ʃkɔːle 'ntsjeːm-i
 go.PRS.3 to DEF-F.SG school(F).SG together-M.PL
 'They go to school together.' (male referents)
 b. 'va a l-a 'ʃkɔːle 'ntsjeːm-a
 go.PRS.3 to DEF-F.SG school(F).SG together-F.PL
 'They go to school together.' (female referents)
- (2) 'kɔmː-u / 'kɔmː-e 'ʃtje // 'kɔmː-i 'ʃteːni // 'kɔmː-a 'ʃteːma
 how-M.SG / how-F.SG be.2SG // how-M.PL be.3PL // how-F.PL be.1PL
 'How are you (SG.F/M)?' 'How are they (M)?' 'How are we (F)?'

The reader is referred to Paciaroni (2023) for a discussion of unusual agreement targets in Ripano (including parts of speech that are generally uninflecting elsewhere) and for earlier references on this fascinating variety, which, however, will not detain us any further here.

3 Types of partial uninflectability

Well-known examples such as Russian *pal'to* 'coat' or Polish *muzeum* instance total (or whole) vs. partial uninflectability (Baerman et al. 2005: 30; Baerman et al. 2017: 28; Spencer 2020: 143).¹ With a variation on the theme of Anna Karenina's principle, while wholly uninflectable lexemes are all alike, once one admits of partial uninflectability, it follows that each partially uninflectable lexeme (or class thereof) can be such in its own way. A tentative taxonomy of these different ways, elaborating on Spencer (2020), is provided in (3):

¹While Spencer (this volume) uses "total uninflectability", some native English speakers I consulted (who are also distinguished morphologists) opine that the adjective *total* sounds slightly awkward when used to modify a noun with the negative prefix *un-*. However, as an anonymous reviewer kindly points out to me, data from the enTenTen21 corpus show that *totally un*ble* occurs more often than *wholly un*ble*.

- (3) An inventory of the types of partial uninflectability:
 - a. constructional uninflectability/non-inflectedness (Spencer 2020: 144)
 - b. featural
 - i. context-free; categorical
 - ii. context-free; optional
 - iii. contextual
 - c. sublexemic (paradigmatic: subset of the paradigm cells)
 - d. sublexemic (syntagmatic: morpheme-related)

In the rest of this section, I will briefly comment on constructional and featural uninflectability (3a–3b), to then move on to sublexemic uninflectability in Section 4, which is the type involved in the cases of agreement loss to be discussed in Section 4. Before proceeding further, a preliminary remark is in order here. Many of the examples of partial uninflectability to be reviewed in what follows will turn out to involve syncretism, as defined in (4a), from Baerman et al. (2005), where it is contrasted with neutralization and uninflectedness (4b):

- (4) a. Baerman et al. (2005: 2): “*syncretism* is the failure to make a morphosyntactically relevant distinction [...] under particular (morphological) conditions”.
- b. Baerman et al. (2005: 32): “*neutralization* is about syntactical irrelevance as reflected in morphology, *uninflectedness* is about morphology being unresponsive to a feature that is syntactically relevant”. [emphasis added]

Thus, one might wonder whether positing a notion “partial uninflectability” runs counter to Occam’s razor, multiplying entities beyond necessity. A tentative answer could be that, while there is indeed some overlap, a) framing (what are in part) the same data in terms of partial uninflectability helps us to see them in a new perspective; and, b) at least some instances of partial uninflectability cannot fall under the scope of the notion syncretism.

The first subtype distinguished by Spencer is constructional uninflectability (3a), as observed e.g. in English nouns used as modifiers (*cat food*) or in the German predicative adjective (5a), contrasted with agreeing attributive adjectives in (5b–5d; in the glosses, case values are omitted for simplicity):

- (5) a. D-er Mann / D-ie Wohnung / D-as Haus
 DEF-M.SG man(M)[SG] / DEF-F.SG flat(F)[SG] / DEF-N.SG house(N)[SG]
 ist schön.
 be.PRS.3SG beautiful
 ‘The man is handsome. // The flat / The house is beautiful.’
 b. ein schön-er Mann
 INDF[M.SG] nice-M.SG man(M)[SG]
 c. ein-e schön-e Wohnung
 INDF-F.SG nice-F.SG flat(F)[SG]
 d. ein schön-es Haus
 INDF[N.SG] nice-N.SG house(N)[SG]
 ‘a handsome man // a nice flat / house’

The *muzeum*-type of uninflectability can be termed featural (3b), whose first subtype (3b-i), context-free or categorical, is illustrated by Italian or Spanish Class 2 adjectives such as *verde* ‘green’ (6b)/(7b) which depart from what Spencer (2020: 146) calls the *inflectional expectation* or *inflectional signature* for that part of speech in the relevant language, in that they only signal number, not gender, contrary to Class 1 adjectives like *alto* in (6a)/(7a) where both feature values are expressed cumulatively.

Two different analyses are discussed in Bond (2019) and Thornton (2019), that regard this lack of inflectional distinction as either syncretism (7b) (given an exhaustive paradigm, some of whose cells host forms that are ambiguous), or featural inconsistency, if the paradigm is taken to be non-exhaustive (6b):²

- (6) a. A paradigm with forms distinguished by two intersecting features (Class 1)
 Italian/Spanish *alto* ‘tall’
- | | | |
|---|------|------------|
| | SG | PL |
| M | alto | alti/altos |
| F | alta | alte/altas |
- b. A paradigm with forms distinguished by a single feature (Class 2)
 Italian/Spanish *verde* ‘green’
- | | | |
|--|-------|--------------|
| | SG | PL |
| | verde | verdi/verdes |

²The relevant definitions and criteria for (6–7) are the following (from Thornton 2019: 91, elaborating on Corbett 2005: 33; Corbett 2007: 9; Corbett 2015: 157; Spencer 2003: 252; Stump 2012: 255, and Bond 2019: 413–414):

“exhaustiveness (there is a cell for every possible feature combination, within a given part of speech), completeness (all cells are filled by a form) and non-ambiguity (each cell contains a form that is different from all the forms contained in the other cells of the same paradigm).”

- (7) a. A paradigm with forms distinguished by two intersecting features

Italian/Spanish *alto* ‘tall’

	SG	PL
M	alto	alti/altos
F	alta	alte/altas

- b. A paradigm with same forms for one of two intersecting features (Class 2)

Italian/Spanish *verde* ‘green’

	SG	PL
M	verde	verdi/verdes
F		

Whatever analysis one chooses for Spanish/Italian Class 2 adjectives such as *verde*, the partial uninflectability (for one feature) is categorical. However, featural uninflectability can be also optional (3b-ii), as illustrated by noun inflection in Wolof (Atlantic, Niger-Congo; Babou & Loporcaro 2016: 10):³

Table 1

	SG	PL	Wolof
	= SG	≠ SG	gloss
a.	këf ki	*këf yi	yëf yi ‘the thing/-s’
b.	bët bi	bët yi	gët yi ‘the eye/-s’
c.	mbagg mi	mbagg yi	%wagg yi ‘the shoulder/-s’
d.	bant bi	bant yi	†want yi ‘the bit/-s of wood’
e.	góor gi	góor ñi	– ‘the man/men’

Most Wolof nouns are of type (e) from Table 1, as a distinct plural form is never attested in the documented history of the language. For some others, a distinct plural form is attested in the past but has now become ungrammatical (Table 1d) or is not (anymore) acceptable for all speakers (Table 1c).⁴ At the other extreme, just a handful of nouns (exemplified with *këf* ‘thing’ in Table 1a) still have a plural form that must be employed categorically when the syntax requires it. Yet

³In each example, the noun is followed by the form of the proximal definite article, which is added in Table 1 because it marks number (in addition to noun class/gender).

⁴As an anonymous reviewer aptly remarked, Table 1d and Table 1e, are synchronically identical, yet information about the documentation of a distinct plural form in past stages of the language for nouns such as the one in Table 1d is not irrelevant in describing the drift towards generalized uninflectability of Wolof nouns, some of which have been uninflectable since the beginning of documentation (Table 1e), while others had a distinct plural form which has now fallen into disuse for all speakers (Table 1d), and still others have a distinct plural form that is acceptable to at least some speakers, as indicated by the % sign in Table 1c.

another group of nouns (Table 1b) still displays a plural form but this is not selected categorically in plural contexts and, as a matter of fact, those nouns are more likely to occur in such contexts, too, in the same form as used in the singular. Obviously, this is a way in which in a language an entire part of speech can become uninflecting, a process now approaching its final stage in the case of Wolof nouns. As long as the change, whose stages are mirrored in Table 1a-e, is not completed, nouns such as those exemplified in Table 1b-c display overabundance (see Thornton 2011) – that is, variation between two cell-mates (in the sense of Loporcaro & Paciaroni 2011: 420) – in the plural cell and thus provide an example of optional featural uninflectability. This optionality is an instance of free variation and thus differs from the next subtype of partial featural uninflectability (3b-iii), which is context-dependent. Consider the forms of the Italian definite article in (8):

		___#C-		___#V-		Italian definite article
		SG	PL	SG	PL	
(8) a.	M	il	i	b.	l	l'ultimo/-a 'the last.M/F.SG'
	F	la	le		le	

Before consonant-initial nouns (8a), the article has a complete paradigm (see footnote 2), with four cells filled with four distinct forms.⁵ Before vowel-initial nouns, however (8b), the singular masculine/feminine forms are syncretic or, once partial uninflectability is admitted, uninflectable for gender, whereas the number contrast is preserved. Compare Romanesco in (9), where the prevocalic allomorph (9b) has become unresponsive to both gender and number and reduced to just one form:

		___#C-		___#V-		Romanesco definite article
		SG	PL	SG	PL	
(9) a.	M	er	(l)i	b.	l	l'urtime/-a/-i/-e 'the last.M/F.SG//M/F.PL'
	F	(l)a	(l)e			

⁵For completeness, it may be mentioned (as an anonymous reviewer reminds me) that the M.SG cell shows an allomorph *lo*, selected (as its plural counterpart *li*) before consonants/consonant clusters that are not exhaustively syllabified in the onset. However, this allomorph is omitted for simplicity in (8a), as it is not relevant to the present argument.

4 Sublexemic uninflectability and loss of object agreement in Romance

Having paved the ground, we now finally come to the last two in the tentative inventory of types of partial uninflectability in (3), which I propose could be called *sublexemic* (3c–3d) and which are those involved in the cases of agreement loss to be discussed in this section.

The first type (3c) is sublexemic in a paradigmatic sense, since uninflectability concerns a subset of the paradigm cells of the given lexeme. This is the usual case of participles in languages such as French, where affixal inflection (and hence agreement) has been heavily impacted by regular sound change: this resulted in a complete loss of suffixal nominal inflection (apart from *liaison* contexts) and a strong reduction of verb inflection as well. From now on, we will focus on past participles since these are the target of direct object agreement across Romance. As seen in (10a), erosion of all affixal inflection through sound change resulted in uninflectability for all regular participles, exemplified with Class 1 *chanté* ‘sang’ in (10b):

(10) Past participle inflection in French, affixal

		weak		strong	
		fāt-e ‘to sing’		pɤãd-ɤ ‘to take’	
		M = F		M = F	
a.	SG = PL	-Ø		SG = PL	pɤi pɤiz
b.	SG = PL	fāt-e		c.	

This is an instance of partial uninflectability, since the verb itself still inflects, if only weakly so, while it is just a subset of the paradigm cells, those of the participle, which have become unresponsive to the features gender and number. Since participles are the target of object agreement, the latter cannot be signalled anymore with regular participles. There are just two groups of root-stressed participles, exemplified with *pris/prise* in (10c) and *fait/faite* in (11), which still inflect, just for gender, never for number, resulting in the mirror image of Italian and Spanish Class 2 adjectives, which inflect for number, not for gender:

- (11) a. Proto-Romance > b. Old French > c. Modern French⁶
- | |
|----------|
| FAC-T-U |
| FAC-T-OS |
| FAC-T-A |
| FAC-T-AS |
- | |
|-----------|
| 'fai-t |
| 'fai-t-s |
| 'fai-t-ə |
| 'fai-t-əs |
- | |
|-----|
| fɛ |
| fɛt |
- M.SG
M.PL
F.SG
F.PL

'done'

Even though with regular participles (10b) agreement is trivially gone, the object agreement rule is still functioning in French, as can be ascertained whenever the participle has feminine forms ending in /z/ or /t/ (see footnote 6), as exemplified in (12b), a context where the conditions for participle agreement are met, though here, too, some variation is reported for the spoken language so that the default masculine form of the participle, which occurs categorically in syntactic contexts where agreement is ungrammatical (12a), can be selected optionally:

- (12) French (Guasti & Rizzi 2002)
- a. Il a mis/*mise la voiture dans le garage.
 he have.3SG put.M/put.F DEF.F.SG car(F) into DEF.M.SG garage(M)
 'He put the car in the garage.'
- b. La voiture, il l'=a mise/%mis dans le garage.
 DEF.F.SG car(F) he DO.3F.SG=have.3SG put.F/put.M into DEF.M.SG garage(M)
 'The car, he put it in the garage.'

Crucially, the syntactic agreement rule is itself independent from the morphology, as shown by cases such as the Walloon dialect of Liège (North-Eastern Gallo-Romance; see Remacle 1956: 148), where the gender contrast is still marked on all participles, including weak ones such as those in (13), yet object agreement in perfective periphrastics is completely gone (just as in Spanish or Portuguese), even in the last syntactic context which resists the gradual demise of participle agreement in other Romance varieties, viz. initially transitive clauses with direct object clitics, as shown in (14):

⁶See Kilani-Schoch & Dressler (2005: 145–146): “Dans une minorité de paradigmes et micro-classes (14 sur 57), le genre féminin est marqué sur le participe passé par les consonnes /z/ et /t/, lorsque la base n’est pas longue.” As seen in (11), the consonant /t/, which has become the exponent of feminine agreement in the Modern French paradigm exemplified in (11c), stems from the original (inherent) inflection of the participle, which, by contrast, was deleted in the masculine forms after the following final vowel had already been deleted by the Old French stage (11b). Conversely, final -/ə/ < Lat. -A in the feminine endings prevented final consonant deletion from applying, thereby preserving the contrast with masculine.

(13) Liégeois

M	F	M	F
trompé	trompêye	vèyou	vèyouwe
'deceived'		'seen'	

- (14) (Èle) dji l'=a vèyou / *vèyouwe.
 (her) I DO.3F.SG=have.1SG seen.M / seen.F
 'I've seen her.'

Of course, if phonetic erosion is complete and no single inflecting participle is left, then the language acquirer loses all evidence for a syntactic rule of object agreement. This has not happened so far in French (see (12b)) but has in Gardiol/Guardiolo, the dialect spoken in the Occitan enclave of Guardia Piemontese, Northern Calabria (Loporcaro 1998: 183f.). On the model of the neighbouring Italo-Romance dialects, Gardiol has merged all final unstressed vowels into schwa, which now occurs only variably. Consequently, for all participles there is now just one form in all syntactic contexts and no inflection for gender or number, even in initially transitive clauses with direct object clitics (as exemplified for French in (12b) and Liégeois in (14)):

(15) Gardiol/Guardiolo (Occitan)

- tə l a sa'r:æ/də'vertə (la 'p:ɔrtə/ʊ k:an'tʃɛd:zɔ)
 'You closed/opened it (the door(F)/the gate(M)).'
- 'ifta 'k:ɔ:z/Ik:e 'd:ziɔk ɔ β^w ε pa 'm:aɪ 'fɔɪt
 'This thing(F) I never did. / That game(M) I never played.'
- 'iftə 'd:ɔt:əɾə z ε pa 'ʃkɪt:ə 'm:ɪ
 'These letters(F) I did not write.'
- kə 'fəʃ:ə l ε pa 'ʃkɪt:ə 'm:ɪ
 'I didn't write that leaflet(M).'
- la 'p:ɔft^ə/ʊ t:ʃa'b:rɛ tə l a 'c:ɛʊt
 'The pasta(F), did you cook it? / The kid(M), did you cook it?'
- ʃi m:ak:a'r:ɔn iʃ ε 'c:ɛʊt
 'The macaroni(M), I cooked them.'

Many dialects of a large area of Central-Southern Italy in which final unstressed vowels merge into schwa show a situation comparable with standard French, in the sense that all regular non-root-stressed participles have become uninflectable, as exemplified with Altamurano (an Apulian dialect) in (16b) (Loporcaro 1998: 66):

(16) Past participle inflection in Altamurano, affixal

			weak			strong		
			la've 'to wash'			's:ælvə 'to untie'		
a.	M	F	b.	M	F	c.	M	F
SG	-ə		SG	la'vetə		SG	's:eltə	's:æltə
PL			PL			PL		

Yet, here the few strong (i.e., root-stressed) participles that still inflect, such as (16c), show agreement even in the very first context from which direct object agreement has disappeared elsewhere, namely transitive clauses with lexical (i.e., non-clitic) direct object, demonstrating that it is still possible to detect crucial syntactic differences (in our case, between this Apulian dialect and French) despite most of the morphological evidence having dissolved because of sound change:

(17) Altamurano

- a. 'aʃ:ə 's:æltə / *'s:eltə la ʃʊ'm:wənd
have.1SG unfastened.F / unfastened.M DEF.F.SG mare(F)
'I have unfastened the mare.'
- b. 'aʃ:ə la'vetə / 'n:ɾt:ə la ʃʊ'm:wənd
have.1SG washed / brought DEF.F.SG mare(F)
'I have washed/brought the mare.'

As the glosses in (17) show – which are morphological, rather than morphosyntactic – only gender agreement is signalled, as in French, albeit by different means, namely stem vowel alternations that arose via metaphony. As seen in (18a), the original masculine singular and plural endings, consisting of final high vowels, caused metaphony, resulting in either raising, as in Maceratese (18b), or diphthongization, as in Leccese (18b), Altamurano and Neapolitan (18c):

(18)	a.	b.	c.
	ProtoRom.	Macer. = Lecc.	Altam. = Neap.
M.SG	COC-T-U	'kɔt:-u	'kwɛt:-u
M.PL	COC-T-I	'kɔt:-i	'kwɛt:-i
F.PL	*COC-T-E	'kɔt:-e	'kɔt:-e
F.SG	COC-T-A	'kɔt:-a	'kɔt:-a
	'cooked'		

A more articulate, synchronic display of the Maceratese data is in (19) (from Paciaroni 2017: 54):

(19) Participle inflection in Maceratese (Paciaroni 2017: 54)

a.				b.				c.			
		SG	PL			SG	PL			SG	PL
N		-o	-			-o	-			-o	-
M	la'at-	-u	-i	'kot:-		-u	-i	'rut:-		-u	-i
F		-a	-e	'kɔt:-		-a	-e	'rot:-		-a	-e
'washed'				'cooked'				'broken'			

Regular (i.e. non-root-stressed) participles in Maceratese inflect only affixally (19a) for number (a two-valued feature like elsewhere in Romance) and gender, which has a third value, the neuter, occurring only in the singular alongside masculine and feminine. The paradigms of strong metaphonic participles, exemplified in (19b–19c), are more complex, since alongside affixal inflection, root allomorphy also co-signals morphosyntactic feature values.⁷ Here, the neuter form shares the root alternant with the masculine, contrasting with the feminine. In other words, number is signalled just on the ending, while there is double exponence of gender. Thus, it is fair to say that the participle stem in (19b–19c) inflects for gender, in a way that synchronically does not just replicate the contrasts marked affixally.⁸ Contrary to the affixal contrasts, that are always there whatever the class of the participle, inflectional marking on the root may occur or not, depending on the class of the participle.

A possible way of framing the inflection class difference between weak (19a) and strong participles (19b–19c) consists in saying that the stem is uninflectable in the former while inflecting for gender in the latter. Thus, weak participles are an

⁷The data in (19–26) are slightly simplified, in that in these dialects there are also root-stressed strong participles which do not show any root alternation, depending on the quality of the (etymological) stressed vowel: all over the area considered here, only stressed mid vowels underwent metaphony, which resulted in the morphological alternations discussed.

⁸Both an anonymous reviewer and Anna M. Thornton (p.c., May 1, 2024) objected to the terminology adopted here, since they “would not say that roots / stems directly inflect or do not inflect, but rather that roots / stems can be, or contain, exponents of inflectional feature values” (Reviewer 2’s report). I fully realize that this criticism is in line with an orthodox application of a word-and-paradigm approach to morphology. However, I believe that the wording adopted here is descriptively adequate, once a) it is admitted that morphemes can be segmented and have a status in morphological theory and b) one observes that the root allomorphy in (18b–18c) and (19b–19c) – as well as in (20b–20c) below – covaries with contrasts in feature-value specifications (here, gender). This wording is also in line with the terminology used in Italian dialectology, where alternations such as those just mentioned are defined as “flessione interna metafonetica” (cf. e.g. D’Elia 1975–1976; Paciaroni et al. 2013: 98; Maturi 2023: 60–61; Mileti 2024: 55).

instance of partial sublexemic uninflectability, not in the sense that uninflectability concerns a subset of the paradigm cells, as in (3c), but rather because it is seen just on the stem, independently of inflectional endings: in other words, this could be termed syntagmatic (i.e. morpheme-related) sublexemic uninflectability (3d).

It would probably not be sensible to claim that the stem of weak participles in (19a) is syncretic for gender: after all, we usually talk of syncretism for affixal morphology or, in inferential-realizational models, for whole word forms occupying paradigm cells, not just for stems which, consequently, have no “inflectional expectation/signature” (Spencer 2020: 146) by themselves.

In previous work of mine (see Loporcaro 2015: 119–123), I argued that among dialects showing multiple exponence of gender along the lines in (19b–19c), a few, spoken in an area straddling Northern Calabria and Southern Basilicata, display a puzzling situation, which results in a violation of the morphology-free syntax principle (see Zwicky & Pullum 1983), according to which

“syntax can be sensitive to abstract properties realized in morphology, but not to specific inflectional marks for these properties (to dative case, say, but not to a particular dative case marking, or to a declension class for nouns)”

(Zwicky 1996: 301)

The violation consists in the fact that in this dialect area, the syntax of direct object agreement is sensitive to the class of the participle. This is illustrated in the following, where the data from one such dialect, *Castrovillarese*, spoken in the province of Cosenza, Northern Calabria (see Pace 1993-1994: 128-147; Loporcaro 2010: 167-171; Loporcaro 2015: 119-123),⁹ are compared with parallel data from *Maceratese*, a dialect in which the morphology of participles is similar but that does not show this syntactic peculiarity. The *Castrovillarese* past participle paradigms, displayed in (20), appear less complex than in *Maceratese* (19):

(20) Participle inflection in Castrovillarese (Loporcaro 2010: 167)

a.		b.		c.	
		SG	PL	SG	PL
M	la'vat-	-ʊ	-I	a'pert-	-ʊ
F		-a		a'pirt-	-a
'washed'		'cooked'		'opened'	

⁹In addition to the dialect of Castrovillari, a similar situation has been described (Loporcaro & Silvestri 2011: 350–353) for those of Verbicaro, San Biase (also in the province of Cosenza), and Viggianello (in the province of Potenza, Basilicata).

First, there are just two gender values and, second, all inflectional suffixes converge into *-i* in the plural as a product of regular sound change. If we compare weak and strong participles, we can say that the former (20a) have a syncretic plural. Another way of putting it, once partial sublexemic uninflectability is assumed, is that weak past participle stems are uninflectable whereas those of strong metaphonic participles inflect for gender, regardless of number. By contrast, on endings gender is neutralized (rather than syncretized), according to the definition in (4b), since affixal endings just mark number, never gender.

Maceratese

- (21) a. *rɔsa ε rvinut-a / *-o jeri*
 Rose be.3SG come-F.SG / -N.SG yesterday
 ‘Rose has come yesterday.’ (unaccusative, weak PtP)
- b. *rɔsa ε mmɔrt-a / *mmort-o*
 Rose be.3SG died\F-F.SG / died\N-N.SG
 ‘Rose has died.’ (unaccusative, strong PtP)
- (22) a. (*l ú-a rɔsa l=a rlaa-a/*-o*)
 DEF.F.SG grapes(F).SG Rose DO3F.SG=have.3SG washed-F.SG/-N.SG
 ‘(The grapes) Rose has washed them.’ (DO clitic, weak PtP)
- b. (*l ú-a rɔsa l=a rkɔrd-a /*
 DEF.F.SG grapes(F).SG Rose DO3F.SG=have.3SG picked\F-F.SG /
 *rkord-o
 picked\N-N.SG
 ‘(The grapes) Rose has picked them.’ (DO clitic, strong PtP)
- (23) a. *rɔsa a rlaa-o/*-a l ú-a*
 Rosa have.3SG washed-N.SG/-F.SG DEF.F.SG grapes(F).SG
 ‘Rose has washed the grapes.’ (lexical DO, weak PtP)
- b. *rɔsa a rkord-o / *rkɔrd-a l ú-a*
 Rosa have.3SG picked\N-N.SG / picked\F-F.SG DEF.F.SG grapes(F).SG
 ‘Rose has picked the grapes.’ (lexical DO, strong PtP)

The (a) vs. (b) examples contain weak vs. strong participles, a morphological difference which, as expected, does not impact on the agreement rule, which prescribes agreement in (21–22) but excludes it in (23), much as in Standard Italian.

Compare now the Castrovillarese counterparts in (24–26):
 Castrovillarese

- (24) a. *rɔsa jε vvinɔt-a/*-ɔ*
 Rose be.3SG come-F.SG/-M.SG
 ‘Rose has come.’ (unaccusative, weak PtP)
- b. *rɔsa jε mmɔrt-a / *mmurt-ɔ*
 Rose be.3SG died\F-F.SG / died\M-M.SG
 ‘Rose has died.’ (unaccusative, strong PtP)
- (25) a. (l *átjin-a*) *rɔsa a llavat-a/*-ɔ*
 DEF.F.SG grapes(F)-SG Rose DO3F.SG=have.3SG washed-F.SG/-M.SG
 ‘(The grapes) Rose has washed them.’ (DO clitic, weak PtP)
- b. (l *átjin-a*) *rɔsa a kkɔt-a /*
 DEF.F.SG grapes(F)-SG Rose DO3F.SG=have.3SG picked\F-F.SG /
 *kkut-ɔ
 picked\M-M.SG
 ‘(The grapes) Rose has picked them.’ (DO clitic, strong PtP)
- (26) a. *rɔsa a llavat-ɔ/*-a l átjin-a*
 Rose have.3SG washed-M.SG/-F.SG DEF.F.SG grapes(F)-SG
 ‘Rose has washed the grapes.’ (lexical DO, weak PtP)
- b. *rɔsa a kkɔt-a / *kkut-ɔ l átjin-a*
 Rose have.3SG picked\F-F.SG / picked\M-M.SG DEF.F.SG grapes(F)-SG
 ‘Rose has picked the grapes.’ (lexical DO, strong PtP)

In Castrovillarese, the expected irrelevance of morphology for the operation of the agreement rules is observed in all syntactic constructions – exemplified in (24) with unaccusative clauses and in (25) with transitive clauses with a clitic direct object – except for the first one from which agreement started to retreat across Romance, viz. transitive clauses with lexical direct objects (26). Here, the occurrence of a participle stem that inflects for gender (26b) correlates with the application of a less restrictive rule (27a) which provides for direct object agreement, while the occurrence of an uninflectable participle stem (26a) correlates with the application of a more restrictive rule (27b) (cf. Loporcaro 2010: 171 for a formal statement of the syntactic rule(s)):

- (27) Participle agreement sensitive to morphology in Castrovillarese, Verbicarese, ecc.:
- a. participles with double exponence of gender (on both the root and the suffix)
 ⇒ agreement rule 1 (including agreement with lexical direct objects)

- b. participles with an uninflectable root, only marking gender on the ending
⇒ agreement rule 2 (more restrictive, excluding agreement with lexical direct objects)

Within the framework of the present discussion, we can conclude that, in this highly unexpected case of interaction of morphology with syntax, the stem uninflectability for gender correlates with the selective demise of agreement and can thus be conceived – as the title goes – as a factor in agreement loss.

5 Conclusion

To conclude, looking at the Romance data from the point of view of uninflectability leads in part to alternative labelling of some phenomena that are usually defined otherwise, mostly as syncretism. However, the discussion in Section 4 of the interplay between partial uninflectability and agreement loss has revealed some phenomena for which this definitional optionality does not seem to hold. In several Romance dialect areas, just a minority of irregular participle stems – those of strong metaphonic participles – inflect for gender while the overwhelming majority of participles (all regular and several irregular too) do not, as was the case in Latin and still is in the major Romance languages (with French a special case, as seen in (10–11)). In this case, following Spencer (2020: 146), it seems hard to argue that gender marking belongs in the “inflectional expectation” or the “inflectional signature” of just the participle stem, which in turn implies that it would be inappropriate to say that non-metaphonic participle stems show gender syncretism.

Finally, the relevance of this kind of sublexemic partial uninflectability has been shown to play a role in the case of the highly surprising morphosyntactic change in the working of direct object agreement that, in a small area of Southern Italy, has resulted in a violation of the morphology-free syntax principle.

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